DOLPHINS

Did You Know?

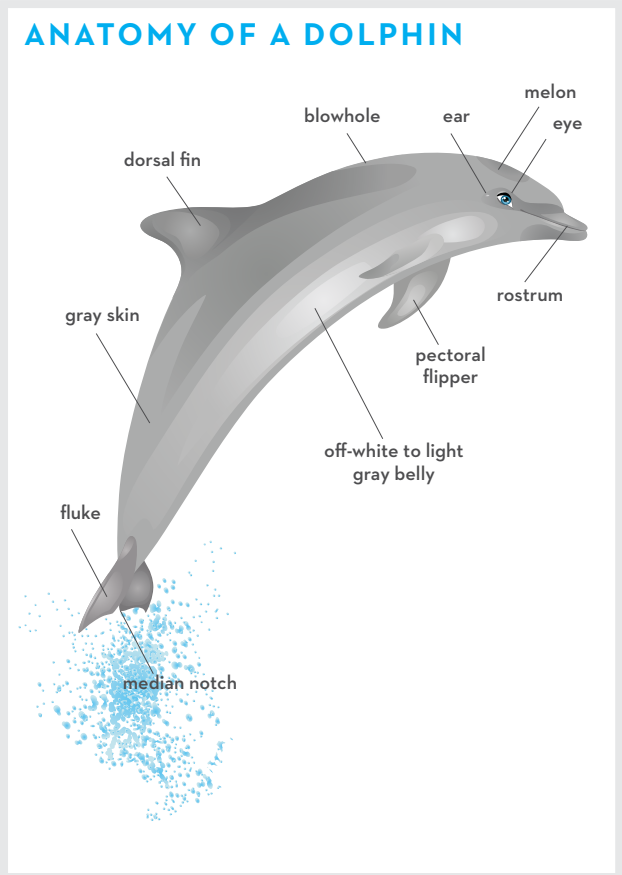
Dolphins belong to a group of marine mammals called toothed whales. The word dolphin comes from the Greek delphis, which means dolphin. The toothed whale group, or Odontoceti, includes not only dolphins but also porpoises, river dolphins, and even the sperm whale. The dolphin family, Delphinidae, which is part of the toothed whale group, includes dolphins such as the bottlenose, spinner, and spotted dolphin, as well as the killer whale, pilot whale, and false killer whale.

Whales live in all the oceans of the world and many species migrate together. Some whales will migrate to reach their local feeding or mating grounds while some migrate to maintain their food supply.

Dolphins Are Mammals

Dolphins are mammals just like humans and have the same basic mammal traits:

- Warm-blooded: Dolphins maintain a constant body temperature.
- Possess hair: Dolphins have a few hairs on their rostrum that they lose after birth.
- Nurse their young: Dolphins have fat-rich milk, which helps the calf gain weight quickly.
- Breathe air: Dolphins breathe through the blowhole on the top of their head.
- Give live birth: Dolphin calves are born in the water.



Dolphin Facts

Adapted For Water

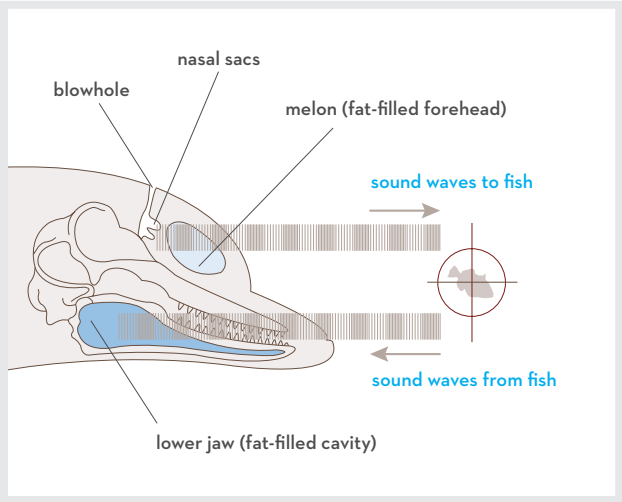
Dolphins have many adaptations that help them survive in the ocean. Their bodies have been streamlined and their limbs have been modified. The pectoral flippers on the sides of their body help the animal steer and stop. The powerful tail flukes help propel the animal, and the dorsal fin provides stabilization while swimming. The pectoral flippers contain the dolphin's arm bones as well as the finger bones, which have been elongated. The dorsal fin is composed of cartilage. Feel the end of your nose: it is also composed of cartilage.

Teeth Are For Tearing

Dolphins and other toothed whales don't chew their food. They use their teeth for grabbing and then either swallow their food whole or rip and tear it into pieces before they eat it. They primarily eat fish or squid. Dolphins will feed as a group using techniques such as encircling a school of fish and then taking turns feeding.

A Sixth Sense

Dolphins have a sixth sense that we are missing: echolocation. They produce sounds in their nasal cavities that are sent out through the melon, their fat-filled forehead. These sounds bounce off an object and return as an echo to the animal through its fat-filled jaw. The sound then moves to the ear and on through the auditory nerve to the brain. With this sense dolphins can determine the size, shape, speed, and density of an object. With practice using this sense, they learn to identify certain species of fish by the echo they receive.



A Social Life

Bottlenose dolphins live in fluid social groups and spend part of each day socializing. These social groups usually number 2 to 15. Individuals will hunt together and care for each other's young. Other types of dolphins such as killer whales, live in family groups called pods.

You Can Help

Dangers For Dolphins

The bottlenose dolphins at Atlantis aren't endangered, but there are many whales and dolphins that are, including the Ganges River dolphin and blue whale. Whales and dolphins have many challenges that they face on a daily basis:

- Trash ingestion
- Entanglement in fishing nets and lines and other litter
- Pollution, including oil spills and agricultural and mining runoff
- Collisions with boats
- Bycatch as part of fishing operations
- Climate change

If you observe an ill or injured dolphin in The Bahamas, please call the Bahamas Marine Mammal Stranding Network at 242-425-3947.

Bottlenose Dolphins Live At Atlantis

Bottlenose dolphins get their name from their snout, or rostrum, which is shaped like a bottle. But that snout is not their nose! Their nasal opening is on top of their head and it's called a blowhole. A muscular flap keeps the water out of its nose. And, yes, they have ears—they have just lost their external ear flaps, or pinnae. You'll have to look carefully to see the ear on the side of the head.

Dolphin Cay

Dolphin Cay is proud to provide the first dedicated rescue and rehabilitation facility in The Bahamas, offering assistance and care for sick or injured marine animals. It is one of the largest and most sophisticated facilities in the world with over 100 professional marine mammal specialists providing the highest level of care for our animals. A portion of the proceeds from dolphin interactions is donated to the Atlantis Blue Project™.

Help Us Shape A Brighter Future

Atlantis Blue Project is dedicated to saving rare and endangered marine species and their extraordinary habitats in The Bahamas and surrounding Caribbean seas. Ongoing preservation efforts include funding scientific research and community outreach as well as conservation and education programs. Due to the support of Atlantis Blue Project™, more than a million acres of marine habitat were preserved in the West Side National Park on Andros Island in The Bahamas.

ATLANTIS
PARADISE ISLAND BAHAMAS

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